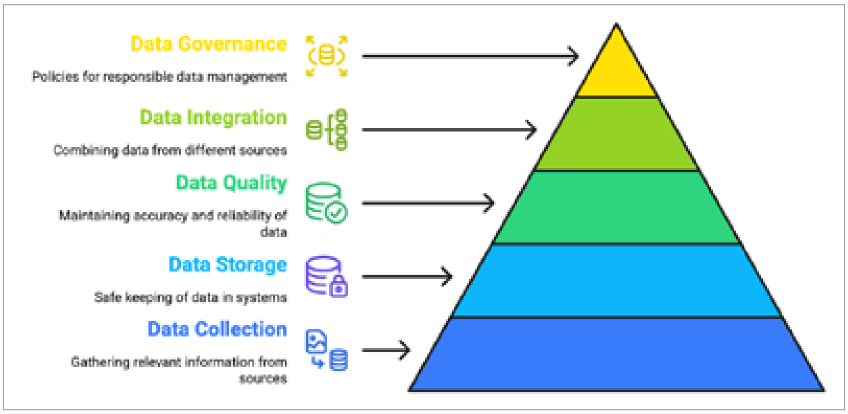

Figure 1: Data management

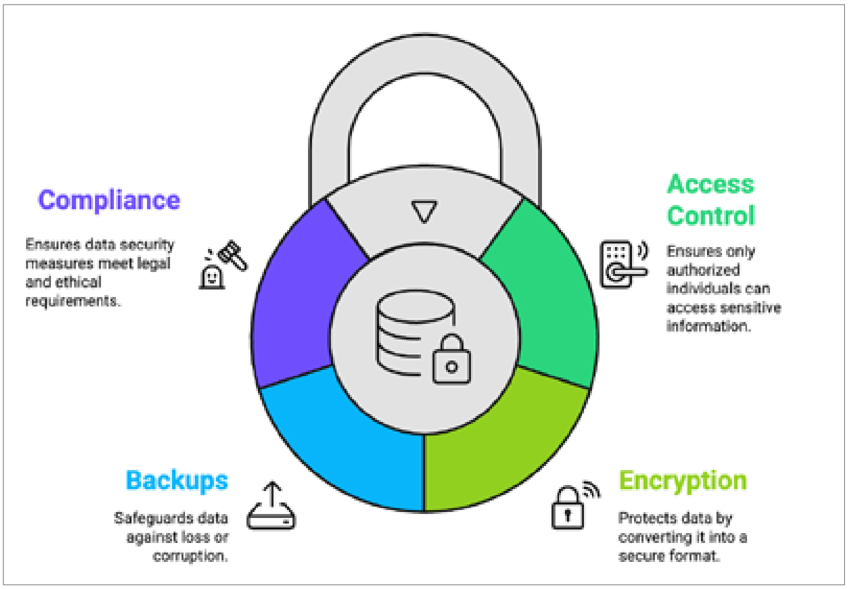

Figure 2: Foundation of data security

Why data management and security matter more than ever

Data volume and complexity are exploding: Today, companies create data from a multitude of sources: websites, mobile applications, IoT devices, and customers. However, managing data is difficult when it grows in size as most departments often use disconnected systems. Therefore, insight gathered across the organisation is limited and decisions are delayed.

Businesses require a consistent, intelligent approach to make sense of the continuing complexity of data.

Cyber threats are at an all-time high: Cyberattacks are now more frequent and damaging. Many companies have experienced significant breaches, including a loss of millions of records, trust and reputation. One breach can wipe out brand equity built over years. This is why data security is fundamental to business continuity today.

Regulations are getting stricter: Legislation is also forcing companies to rethink how they collect and safeguard data. Laws such as GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, etc, require companies to be transparent, provide safeguards, and gain consent. The penalties for not complying are severe.

Compliance is not just to avoid fines — it is also an opportunity to showcase to customers that you care about their privacy.

Customers expect transparency and trust: Modern customers are more aware of the significance of data than ever before. They want to understand how their data is used and expect companies to be honest and ethical. Companies that do not do so may face the backlash — from social media outrage to customer churn.

A company that can be trusted has a competitive advantage. Good data practices help build that trust and develop loyalty for your brand.

How to build a strong data foundation that works

To leverage data as a true business enabler, businesses need to formulate an intentional, structured plan that takes people, processes, and technology into account. Here's how organisations can provide a solid foundation for data-driven success and be future-ready.

Step 1: Break the silos and establish a unified architecture: Many organisations are storing data in silos, resulting in inconsistent insights and operational inefficiencies. The first step is to create a unified data architecture that centralises access to data so that every department has access to the same source of truth. Integration can come through modern cloud platforms, application programming interfaces (APIs), or data lakes; either way, integration to unlock value is an imperative.

Step 2: Embed security into every stage of the data lifecycle: Security cannot be an afterthought. It must be baked into every stage in the data lifecycle from the point data is captured, through to the point where it is archived or deleted. Organisations can utilise zero trust models or privacy by design practices to protect data at each point it's collected or shared rather than at the controller's convenience.

Step 3: Make data culture a shared experience: Technology, on its own, will be of little use if people do not